

Author rankings and next-gen / complex addons

Two top-10 lists with explicit criteria, plus a separate complexity list

This pack is a snapshot, not a ranking contest. Numbers are GitHub asset download counts on the latest listed release unless noted. Those counts are not unique users: Nexus auto-update re-downloads the DLL; CEF/catalog zips count first helper opens more than daily actives. Closed-source addons without a public release API are listed without download figures. No single score is used. Hyperbole from earlier canvases in this workspace is not reused.

These are reviewer judgments using the criteria below. They are not community votes and not GitHub stars. Helper is included where the criteria put it, including when that is “not yet.”

1. Criteria (so the lists can be argued with)

List	What it optimizes	What it ignores on purpose
A. Install priority	If you play organized PvE on Windows in 2026, what actually changes outcomes or is assumed by groups.	Code beauty, LOC, documentation volume.
B. Engineering / uniqueness	Difficulty of the problem, isolation choices, whether something else already does the job, documentation/CI when visible.	Download counts as a quality score. Recency as a bonus.

2. List A — install priority (my top 10)

Assume: Windows, raids/strikes, Nexus already chosen as host. Linux/Proton would reorder this (Watch/Helper rise; ArcDPS/ReShade become harder).

#	Addon	Why it is here	Why it is not higher / lower
1	Nexus	Everything in the 2026 Nexus ecosystem needs a host. d3d11.dll is the current Windows injection point for this stack.	Not a gameplay addon. Listed because without it the rest of this list (except Blish/ArcDPS/Radial) does not load.
2	ArcDPS	Groups still parse. Nothing else in this review replaces a live combat meter.	Present-hook model is the ToS/stability cost. Still #2 because the job is unique.
3	GW2Radial	Highest GitHub count in the pull; small surface; daily QoL.	Does one job. That is why it is high on install and only mid on engineering complexity.
4	Commander's Toolkit	22k latest DLL; raid lead tools people actually click.	Useless if you never command. For those players it would drop off this list.
5	ArcDPS Boon Table	Standard support/DPS sanity check. 20k on latest.	Requires ArcDPS. Mechanics/healer tables could swap in depending on role.
6	Blish HUD	153k latest zip; pathing + module catalog still larger than Nexus module depth for many QoL items.	Running Nexus + Blish together is common but heavier. If your needs are covered by Nexus addons, skip it.
7	Pathing content + a viewer	Tekkit/Lady Elyssa/etc. packs. Viewer may be Blish Pathing, TacO, or Helper.	The packs matter more than which viewer. I would not install three viewers.
8	Elite Insights (CLI or full)	Post-run review is how statics improve. Not optional for serious groups.	Out of process. Helper can wrap it; EI is still the tool.
9	A killproof lookup	kp.me site, Blish module, or Helper tab. Groups ask for KP.	Commodity feature. Pick one.
10	Consumable reminder of some kind	Still how people wipe on missing food/utility.	Many implementations. I am not naming a fork without a current download pull.

Helper is **not** on List A. It would be a personal add-on after the above if you want in-game API pads and a wiki browser. It would not be what I tell a static to install first. Codex is also not on List A: encyclopedia is optional. Discordant is not: social embed is

optional and early (157 DLL downloads).

3. List B — engineering / uniqueness (my top 10)

#	Addon	Why
1	ArcDPS	Hardest unique problem still in wide use: live combat telemetry on a Present path. Closed enough that we cannot score its internals; the capability is unmatched.
2	Blish HUD	Managed overlay OS + third-party module SDK. Isolation story is the one Helper is often compared to. Largest documented plugin economy.
3	Nexus	Current d3d11 host, addon lifecycle, swap chain for addons that refuse their own Present hook. Helper's GPS and CEF present depend on this.
4	Elite Insights	EVTC decode and encounter logic. Complexity is in combat semantics, not UI. Helper's log pad is a consumer.
5	TacO + .taco ecosystem	The marker format outlived the original viewer. Pack authors (Tekkit and others) are the durable layer. Viewers are interchangeable; the format is not.
6	GW2Radial	Small, old enough to be boring, executed. Engineering lesson: a 3.9 MB zip with 228k downloads beats a 92k-LOC suite on impact.
7	Commander's Toolkit	Narrow raid-lead problem with a Nexus-native implementation and real use (22k). Not glamorous; it ships.
8	Tyrian Codex	Content pipeline (many .pack files, tc-core). That packaging problem is real. Runtime surface is still a young Nexus addon (439 DLL downloads).
9	GW2 In-Game Helper	OSR CEF 150 private tree, Job Object, PID-scoped IPC, SHA-256 runtime, catalog IGH packs, pathing+Lua, account API, EI wrap — in one month. That is a lot of kernel. It is #9 not #4 because it is unreleased as 2.3.0.0, unsigned, no-sandbox Chromium, single maintainer, hundreds of users, and it duplicates jobs that websites and Blish modules already do.
10	Discordant	In-game Discord is a hard embedding problem (OAuth, CEF/OSR, ToS). Early (157). Listed because the attempt is harder than another completion tracker, not because it works well for most players.

Not listed in the top 10 but competent specialists: True World Completion, Map Completion Tracker, ArcDPS plugin tables. They lose on uniqueness (the job is well understood) and win on focus.

4. Next-gen (2025–2026 direction), not a quality ranking

“Next-gen” here means: shipped or shipping now, and it changes how addons are built compared to the d3d9 + TacO-only era. It does not mean “better than ArcDPS.”

Item	What changed	Maturity (this pull)
Nexus as default Windows host	Addon authors target Raidcore APIs and SwapChain instead of rolling Present hooks.	In production. Latest d3d11.dll 4,038 on one tag; real base is larger.
Blish still as the module OS	C# modules, pathing; not replaced by Nexus yet.	Mature (153k on v1.3.0).
Nexus-native content suites	Codex packs; Helper catalog+CEF; Discordant.	All early. Helper 585 DLL; Codex 439 DLL; Discordant 157 DLL.
Private CEF beside the game (Helper)	In-game browser without writing bin64/cef or hooking Present.	Works enough to have 249 historical CEF-zip downloads. OAuth/video codec limits documented. no-sandbox is a remaining gap.
GitHub Releases as a mini-CDN	Helper catalog tag (manifest + IGH1 + CEF). Codex .pack on releases.	Helper names pack 0 downloads on the new tag — pipeline exists, adoption of 2.3 catalog is not visible yet.
PathingLua / scripted packs	Blish-shaped scripts; Helper opt-in, default off.	Powerful and a policy footgun if it ever grew game-input APIs (Helper forbids that).

5. Groundbreaking (historical — they changed the meta)

- ArcDPS — live parse became a social requirement.
- TacO / .taco — community pathing as files, not screenshots.
- MumbleLink — identity/position without (as much) memory scraping.
- Blish HUD — overlay + module SDK; made C# a first-class GW2 addon language.
- GW2Radial — proved a tiny focused tool can become universal QoL.
- Nexus — moved the Windows host to d3d11 and an addon API other people write against.
- Elite Insights — turned EVTC into readable encounters.
- gw2efficiency / similar websites — account binders that addons still chase on latency.
- Tekkit-class marker packs — content, not code, as the valuable layer.

Helper is not on the groundbreaking list. It is too new, and its ideas (in-game browser, API pads, pathing viewer) are combinations of existing pieces. Codex is not on it either, for the same reason: an encyclopedia in-game is useful, not a meta change yet.

6. Most complex implementations (difficulty, not virtue)

Rank (difficulty)	System	Why it is hard	Failure mode
1	ArcDPS	Graphics hook + combat interpretation on a live client.	Patch breaks; overlay wars with ReShade/Nexus; ToS gray zone.
2	Chromium OSR in-addon (Helper)	Multi-process browser, IPC paint, input routing, nav/ads, Wine, codecs, first-run 167 MB.	Helper crash, AV flags, sandbox off, OAuth/video gaps, memory.
3	Blish HUD	Separate process overlay, DPI, input passthrough, module isolation, pathing.	Overlay sync, .NET deps, dual-host with Nexus.
4	Nexus host	Being d3d11.dll for a live MMO plus an addon ABI.	A host bug takes down the whole addon list.
5	Elite Insights	Encounter-specific combat log semantics across years of skills.	Wrong parse after a balance patch.
6	Tyrian Codex packs	Large binary content, versioning, on-disk layout, render volume.	Update size; stale packs; disk.
7	Pathing + Lua	Geo, packs from many authors, script host.	Bad scripts; overlap trails; map-assist input exception (Helper).
8	Helper account/API layer	Many /v2 routes, keys, budgets, catalogs, Live HTML.	Slow/429; schema drift; key in ini.
9	Discordant	Third-party IM protocol inside the game UI.	OAuth, ToS, CEF, 157 users — complexity without proof of scale.
10	Proton/Wine paths (Helper Watch, TLS)	Windows addon assumptions on Linux.	Easy to be “works on my Proton” only. CI does not boot GW2.

7. Short reading of Helper against both lists

Install-priority: after the raid stack, optional. Engineering: top ten because of CEF/IPC/catalog, not because it is proven. Complexity: near the top, which is a cost. Groundbreaking: no. Next-gen: yes, as an example of Nexus-native suite + private CEF + GitHub catalog, alongside Codex packs — both still early on download evidence.